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most respects Mattie is a much harder customer than careless, sweet-tempered Huck. Where Huck is barefoot and "uncivilised", living happily in his hoghead barrel, Mattie is a pure product of civilisation as a Sunday-school teacher in 19th-century Arkansas might define it; she is a strait-laced Presbyterian, prim as a poker ("I would not put a thief in my mouth to steal my brains," she says coolly to the drunken Rooster); tidy, industrious, frugal, with a head for figures and a shrewd business sense. Her deadpan manner is reminiscent of Buster Keaton: Mattie, too, is a Great Stone Face; she never cracks a smile when recounting the undignified and ridiculous situations in which she finds herself; and even predicaments of great danger fail to draw violent emotion from her.

But this deadpan flatness serves a double purpose in the novel, for if Mattie is humourless, she is also completely lacking in qualities like pity and self-doubt, and her implacable stoniness — while very, very funny — is formidable, too, in a manner reminiscent of old tinctypes and cartes des visites of Confederate soldier boys: dead-eye killers with rumpled hair and serious angel faces. One cannot picture Huckleberry Finn in the same light; for while Huck is an adventuresome spirit, duty and discipline are wholly foreign to him; conscripted by any army, any cause, he would

desert in short order, slipping away the first chance he got to his easy riverbank life.

Mattie on the other hand is the perfect soldier, despite her sex. She is as tireless as a gun dog; and while we laugh at her single-mindedness, we also stand in awe of it. In her Old Testament morality, in her legalistic and exacting turn of mind, in the thunderous blackness of her wrath ("What a waste! ... I would not rest easy until that Louisiana cur was roaring and screaming in hell!") she is less Huck Finn's little sister than Captain Ahab's.

True Grit is an adventure story, and though the two books in most respects could not be more different, Mattie's quest in some ways reflects Dorothy Gale's in *The Wizard of Oz*. Practical Dorothy, throughout all her trials, is really only working her way back home to Kansas; while practical Mattie, with her own mission and her own brace of unlikely travelling companions, is riding in the historical shadow of a very different Kansas: the mythical outlaw territory of Quantrill and his Confederate raiders.

While Quantrill — a brilliant tactician — was romanticised in some quarters as an outlaw chieftain à la Alexandre Dumas, the massacre he led at the abolitionist town of Lawrence, Kansas, is considered the worst atrocity of the American civil war, and history has tended to view Quantrill as a

cold-blooded killer. (One man — shot five times when he tried to surrender — was left for dead by his assailant with the parting advice: "Tell old God that the last man you saw on earth was Quantrill.") Rooster, presumably, has come by some of his famous meanness under Quantrill's tutelage; the incident with Odus Wharton and the bodies in the fire does seem to have some parallels with unpleasant incidents in historical accounts of raids at Lawrence and Centralia; and certainly he has picked up Quantrill's reputed habit of riding against his enemy with the reins of his horse between his teeth and a revolver in each hand. And yet it is scoundrelly old Rooster who — like Huck Finn, revolting instinctively against the accepted brutality of his day — rises unexpectedly to *True Grit*'s moments of justice and nobility. He does this in a number of minor comical respects (as in his satisfying encounter with the two "wicked boys" who are tormenting the mule on the riverbank) not to mention the novel's extraordinary climax. But perhaps the most gratifying moment in the entire book is when Rooster is jolted from his ambivalence about Mattie by the sight of LaBoeuf falling upon her with a switch:

I began to cry, I could not help it, but more from anger and embarrassment than pain. I said to Rooster, "Are you going to let him do this?"

'Ahab's little sister' ... Kim Darby as Mattie Ross with John Wayne (right) as Rooster Cogburn and Glen Campbell as LaBoeuf in the 1969 film of *True Grit*

He dropped his cigarette to the ground and said, "No, I don't believe I will. Put your switch away, LaBoeuf. She has got the best of us."

"She has not got the best of me," replied the Ranger. Rooster said, "That will do, I said."

LaBoeuf paid him no heed. Rooster raised his voice and said, "Put that switch down, LaBoeuf! Do you hear me talking to you?"

LaBoeuf stopped and looked at him. Then he said, "I am going ahead with what I started."

Rooster pulled his cedar-handled revolver and cocked it with his thumb and threw down on LaBoeuf. He said, "It will be the biggest mistake you ever made, you Texas brushpopper."

True Grit, in short, begins where chivalry meets the frontier — where the old Confederacy starts to merge and shade away into the Wild West. And without giving anything away, I can say the book ends at a travelling Wild West show in Memphis in the early 1900s: which is to say, at once in the 20th century and firmly enshrined in myth and legend.

True Grit was first published in 1968. When it came out, Roald Dahl wrote that it was the best novel to come his way in a long time. "I was going to say it was

the best novel to come my way since ... Then I stopped. Since what? What book has given me greater pleasure in the last five years? Or in the last 20?"

Certainly when I was growing up in the 1970s, *True Grit* was widely thought to be a classic; when I was about 14 years old, it was read along with Walt Whitman and Nathaniel Hawthorne and Edgar Allan Poe in the Honors English classes at my school. Yet (because, I believe, of the John Wayne film, which is good enough but which doesn't do the book justice) *True Grit* vanished from the public eye, and my mother and I, along with many other Portis fans, were reduced to scouring used-book stores and buying up whatever stock we could find because the copies we lent out so evangelically were never returned. (In one particularly dark moment, when my mother's last copy had disappeared and a new one was nowhere to be had, she borrowed the library's copy and then pretended that she had lost it). Now — thankfully — the book is back in print in America, and I am delighted to have the honour of introducing a new reprint in the UK, and of introducing Mattie Ross and Rooster Cogburn to a new generation of readers.

This is an edited version of Donna Tartt's introduction to a new edition of *True Grit*, published by Bloomsbury on January 17. To order a copy please see the details of the Guardian book service on page 20.

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